

Maugham Library

No. 172

THE HERITAGE of FLEET STREET

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A building has stood on the site of the Maugham Library since 1217, when King Henry III created a house as a refuge for Jews who had converted to Christianity. The office continued even after Jews were expelled in 1290. In 1377, it was merged with the office of Master of the Rolls, responsible for storing the Court of Chancery's long parchment scrolls, first kept in the chapel.

The original House of Converts was demolished in 1771, replaced by a new building, and later by the current Rolls Building, designed by Sir James Pennethorne and completed in 1856 as England's first fire-proof public record office. One medieval arch, featuring a statue of Henry III, survives in the Chancery Lane frontage.

The Ancient Rolls Chapel, now the Weston Room, houses treasures including 16th–17th-century tombs, stained glass from 1611, a bell from 1611, and a restored mosaic floor, reflecting the building's rich history.

